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# Rose

## April 1943

The sisters had been in this remote town on the border of Germany and Bohemia for nearly five months. Rose anticipated the arrival of spring. Every morning on the way to the factory, she looked out for the green shoots of tulips and hyacinths pushing up through the ground. But the mornings and evenings remained cold and damp. The days were too short and none had yet appeared.

Now that Léa went every day to the sick bay to type Josef's reports, she no longer met Rose at the end of their factory shifts. And Rose, seeking a warm place to sketch—the barracks had little heating—went to the church in the center of town, which was mostly empty in the evenings. The Gothic windows and the towering altar with gold figures reminded her of the times she'd gone to the cathedral in Orléans with her mother and sister to celebrate mass at Easter and Christmas. All week she'd been sketching the altar and was almost finished.

Tonight, she entered and sat on a pew at the back. After a day of back-breaking work lacquering all those brass cylinders on the assembly line—the rattling machines, their pistons breathing in and out like angry dragons she'd read about in fairy tales—sitting in the warmth and quiet was a gift. Even the sight of a few forsythia and pussy willow branches tucked in the stone vases on either side of the altar lifted her spirits.

Before taking out her sketchbook, she noticed, in the corner at the rear of the church, a stack of candles. They were likely for the altar. Rose hadn't seen any votive candle stands; she'd asked Léa about them, and she'd said that the Protestant church here didn't make offerings to saints like she was